



From Erving to Goffman

A Work in Performance?

Yves Winkin

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Goffman in the Open Series

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PART THREE

The Lecture as Performance

But Why Do Academics Give Lectures?

Academics accept lecture invitations because part of their mission is to disseminate knowledge, over and above formal courses and seminars. But in reality, there is more to it than that, and it can be complicated to explain. The invitation, wherever it comes from, is always flattering, and the desire to be the hero for an evening is almost irrepressible. It has to be said, too, that few academics refuse a little extra income if a fee is involved. They may also see the lecture as an opportunity to see a lot of the country and meet some interesting people. One can find many ways to rationalize such a trip, yet that will not stop them from wondering after the fact why they traveled so many miles for a few students typing away on their phones, a few senior citizens listening with their eyes closed and their mouths open, and a few colleagues who did not take time to read anything relevant in advance. Even so, a certain optimism endures; the next time an invitation comes their way, they will probably accept, hoping it will go better.

In the academic world, we can distinguish at least three categories of speakers: the laborer, the rentier, and the banker. The vast majority of academics fall into the first category, being only occasional speakers. They rarely present outside their national academic milieu; very few will go beyond this to address peers abroad, or even the “general public.” To reach such audiences, they will need to have been previously spotted by the media when a

book is released or thanks to an interview on some promising topic. Some will manage to land the Grail, but this is usually a one-off opportunity: for example, a lecture tour of the French Institutes. A Grail not only because it is pleasant to go abroad, to be welcomed, catered to in a diplomatic environment, but also because there is no need to negotiate fees: You just accept what is offered. When you have to bargain while maintaining your academic dignity, that is another story. If you have no secretary to act as intermediary (an increasingly rare privilege these days), you have to negotiate your fees while the head of the inviting organization explains on the phone that subsidies were lowered the previous year. As you listen, the angel on your right shoulder whispers in your ear: “You’re a civil servant, aren’t you?” while the devil on your left shoulder retorts: “Do you think X [insert the name of a well-known colleague here] would mind being paid so much?”

X belongs to the second category, that of symbolic rentiers, who live on a well-managed fund of notoriety. We have all noticed the names that move tirelessly from city to city, far beyond the academic arena. The same photo of their face appears regularly in cultural magazines, on posters, on the internet. They are in fact managed by a specialized firm, which places them in conference cycles, think tanks, and professional associations. Their speaking fees rival those of successful authors and media personalities. Some last a very long time, but in general, the full cycle doesn’t go beyond twenty years or so. I won’t name names—that would be cruel. So just imagine that I am speaking about the prominent names in your area.

Finally, there are the symbolic bankers, very few in number, who are much in demand but respond relatively infrequently to invitations. They come first and foremost to help a younger colleague, to affirm their solidarity, to express their friendship. By offering a little of their symbolic capital, they lose none; on the contrary, they gain even more. Just as prestigious publishing houses welcome a young author, or famous art galleries showcase a still-unknown artist, these speakers operate in a very special economy, in which the gift of their time, their presence, and their knowledge is not billed as an ordinary service and is not even balanced by an immediate counter-gift. In fact, their services are part of a cycle from which they will benefit in the long term, but which is rarely revealed. In fact, the less the bankers and their protégés say, the better the return. Pierre Bourdieu, who was one of these symbolic bankers, has described the mechanisms in several of his writings (Bourdieu 1977, 1984; Lebaron, 2020).

Goffman: Rentier or Banker?

Goffman certainly was not a casual speaker. He clearly was a professional speaker, but he never left the academic field. He never gave a corporate talk, for example. But should we see him more as a rentier, exploiting a stock of well-established lectures, or as a symbolic banker, lending support to a younger colleague? The answer is quite clear: He was a rentier who did not hesitate to produce the same lecture repeatedly. Three talks Goffman presented often were the one on *Frame Analysis*, the one on “The Lecture,” and the one on *Gender Advertisements*. However, it is worth mentioning that this last one—his “road show” with a carousel of slides—was often offered to feminist groups, and in this sense he played the role of a symbolic banker, if not an activist. His three visits to the University of Tennessee earned him nothing in symbolic terms, and while he was certainly also drawing on his stock as a rentier, he was above all a banker giving his capital to two little-known sociologists. The same could be said of his first trip to Davis to support MacCannell.

In this way, Goffman evades simple classification. We need to take a closer look. Goffman as lecturer cannot be reduced to rentier or banker. When he gave a lecture, it can be said that he performed it, as a musician performing his score. But in another sense, it was the lecture that performed Goffman—that is, the lecture helped him to emerge as Goffman, the increasingly well-known, increasingly mythical sociologist. By dint of producing lectures, Goffman produced Goffman, in a performative operation that is quite exceptional in the history of Western social sciences in the twentieth century.

The 1977 University of Michigan Lecture on the Lecture

On April 22, 1977, Goffman delivered the annual Katz-Newcomb Memorial Lecture at the University of Michigan.¹ His lecture was titled “The Lecture.” He actually read a paper he had meticulously prepared. Only a few spontaneous elements, probably annotated in the margins or between the lines, made this performance unique. In the publication which ensued, he inserted a paragraph or two into the text and explained in a preface that he had not changed the format in order to reveal “certain framing problems.” He did not go so far as to propose an “unedited transcription of an oral

¹ While Goffman mentions the year 1976 in *Forms of Talk* (1981, p. 160), the conference program sent by the University of Michigan proves that it was 1977. I would like to thank Jacob Nugent of the Bentley Historical Library for his research.

recording, accompanied by a continuous indication of gestures, tempo and elisions" (1981, p. 160). This hybrid version is found in *Forms of Talk*, Goffman's only lecture published during his lifetime. Goffman's talk was a rather exceptional exercise in reflexivity on the part of a social scientist, which proves that he took a close interest in what the lecture did to its author (its performer). Goffman's lecture mentions a fellow anthropologist, Charles O. Frake (1977), author of a text quite similar in intent (a lecture on the exercise of presenting). But Goffman's analysis is more in-depth than Frake's, even dizzying at times. Yet Goffman sought to keep his audience engaged: He addressed them directly ("You will note that"), used the first person, and did not hesitate to make short, overtly humorous digressions—at least at the beginning. It seems he may have been deploying the well-known rhetorical device of *captatio benevolentiae* (seizing the kindness) through playful banter, as North American orators very often do. Clearly, this was a real lecture, not an article in disguise. But it was a demanding lecture nonetheless, and it is not certain that the Ann Arbor audience followed it all the way through. In the following, I will analyze the six sections of Goffman's text, to see exactly what he was doing.

In the first section, he tries to establish his authority as a speaker by talking about his situation on stage, saying he is not "another self-appointed cut-up, optimistically attempting a podium shuck" (Goffman, 1981, p. 162). He is doing frame analysis, and he is going to draw on the resources offered by the situation to demonstrate some notions in this field. For example, Goffman posits from the outset that there is a boundary between the situation the lecture is about and the situation in which it takes place, but that this boundary is particularly fragile when the presentation is precisely about the properties of presentations: All you have to do is talk about this boundary and it vanishes.

The second section sets out the various constituent elements of a lecture, which Goffman begins by defining as "an institutionalized extended holding of the floor in which a speaker imparts his views on a subject, these thoughts comprising what can be called his 'text'" (p. 165). So, there is a speaker and a text. Then, there is also a stage (Goffman does not mention the presence of a table; he speaks of a speaker "ordinarily standing," which must have been true in his case), and an audience, "ordinarily seated," who cannot react verbally. The audience is supposed to be captivated by the speaker's ideas, not by his performance. And yet, we speak of performance ("in the theatrical sense of the term," says Goffman) and accept that the lecture is part of

a “social fuss,” which presupposes organization, other players (sponsors, committee members, presenters), and a tacit alliance between the speaker and the inviting bodies. The eminent guest will be encouraged to calibrate his remarks for the “general public,” making concessions at the expense of his subject in order to transmit knowledge. To deliver a successful talk, he must also respect the limitation of his speaking time and the presence of actors other than himself. What Goffman writes at this point necessarily echoes real-life experiences:

And he is encouraged to accept all manner of rampant intrusion from interviewers, photographers, recording specialists, and the like—intrusions that often take place right in the middle of the heat of the occasion. (If at any moment you should get the notion that a speaker really is fully caught up in talking to you, take note of his capacity to treat photographers as though they weren’t interrupting his talk. Such apparent obliviousness can, of course, come from his involvement with you, as opposed to his commitment to publicity, but don’t count on it. (pp. 170–171)

This passage also echoes his entire oeuvre. The vocabulary may have changed, but the same themes recur, sometimes as far back as his doctoral thesis. Once again, there is a question of impression management and commitment (the speaker must succeed in making it seem as if he’s totally invested in his relationship with his audience), of the self as a performed character to which one adds faith or not (does the audience trust the speaker when he shows them that he is not interested in the photographer?). All this is said between the lines, without explicit reference to his previous works. This subtext emerges with careful reading, and by that same token, it would have been difficult for Goffman’s original, listening audience to grasp.

The third section is very short. It takes up the question of the illusion of spontaneity produced by the speaker and the credit given to him or her based on the three modes of speech production: memorization, reading aloud, and spontaneous speech. Spontaneous speech is the ideal: Texts read or memorized must give the illusion of spontaneous speech. But spontaneous speech is never totally spontaneous because the speaker produces one sentence while already formulating the next in his head. Spontaneous speech is therefore short-term memorized speech, a reading aloud of a mental text. Again and again, the question of credible illusion is at the heart of Goffman’s thinking, as evidenced by his description of the skills that speakers eventually acquire:

And they mark a natural turning point in fresh talking or aloud reading a lecture when they realize they can give thought to how they seem to be doing, where they stand in terms of finishing too soon or too late, and what they plan to do after the talk—without these backstage considerations becoming evident as their concern; for should such preoccupation become evident, the illusion that they are properly involved in communicating will be threatened. (p. 172)

Only a seasoned lecturer could write a sentence like that. This shows just how much experience Goffman had in this field. Although he always delivered highly scripted lectures, giving no illusion of spontaneous speech because, as he puts it bluntly, “of [his] incompetence,” he demonstrates a real mastery of the oratorical ropes. For example, when he asks in the conclusion of the third section what distinguishes a lecture from the text that might be distributed instead, he provides a classic *a priori* answer: A lecture cannot be reduced to its content or to the gestures accompanying the enunciation. A subtle balance needs to be struck: Too few gestures and the audience’s attention risks fading away; too many gestures and the audience’s attention risks focusing on effects to the detriment of content. To explain this “score,” Goffman (p. 173) uses a formal rhetorical approach in his writing which is not reflected in the French translation of the text: He repeats the same verbal attack twice consecutively (“*At best . . . At best . . .*”), he repeats the same phrase twice in a long sentence (“*if, because of what I say . . . , if, because of what I refer to . . .*”), he provides three equivalent words where one would suffice (“This partition, this membrane, this boundary, is the tickler”). And let us not forget that this text was intended to be read in public. The passage that evokes the balance, but also the boundary to be found between content and form, is precisely the one in which Goffman shows a specificity of oral discourse at work. It’s hard to prove that he was conducting these repetitions with a finger or a hand. But we can imagine it.

This rhetorical outburst subsides at the start of the fourth section, which is the longest and most technical. Goffman opens it with a short, dry sentence, as if to illustrate what he is about to discuss: “Now consider footing and its changes” (p. 173). The notion of *footing* is part of the apparatus that Goffman develops in the last chapter of *Frame Analysis*, entitled “Frames of Conversation” (1974, pp. 496–559). *Footing* means to have one’s foot well stabilized on the ground. Analogously, we can change “position” several times in a lecture, take a step to the side, open a parenthesis, while landing back on our feet, in balance, each time. This is what Goffman analyzes in terms of the

“textual self,” the self that emanates from the written text, possibly read by a third party if the speaker cannot physically be present. He proposes four “places where position changes”: keyings, text brackets, text-parenthetical remarks, and performance contingencies. In each case, the aim is to distance oneself from the initial text, or to draw emotionally closer to it, by means of a gesture or a variation in tone. Goffman gracefully refers to the competent lecturer able to read with “a twinkle in his voice” while “slightly raising his vocal eyebrows” (1981, p. 175). For text framing, he chooses the image of the speaker who “backs down from his horse” at the moment of his conclusions and goes “back to the audience as merely another member of it” (p. 175). In particularly concrete terms, he evokes the “bracket rituals such as lighting a cigarette, changing from a standing to a sitting position, drinking a glass of water, etc.” (p. 176). Behind each example, we sense the experienced speaker who has mastered his register to the point of easily making use of it as he speaks. Thus, when he mentions the third change of position, parentheses, he asks: “May I digress for a moment?” and concludes with a “To return” (pp. 178–179). The concrete demonstration of the theoretical concept is clear.

Goffman ends this section with a return to the classical model of communication, which applies particularly well to the lecture, with its sender (the speaker) and receiver (the audience). But other elements are also involved: most critically, noise—that is, any obstacle to a perfect transmission of the message between speaker and audience. Goffman evokes a series of performance contingencies, from sniffing to denture whistling. If the lecturer notices an issue, he or she may make a comment or “repairing remark,” resulting in a split between the role of facilitator and that of author. This “reflexive frame-breaking” is very common in friendly conversation, but extremely rare on live television, for example. Lectures fall somewhere in between: Listeners are usually tolerant. But Goffman concludes by warning us not to exploit the vein too much. Once again, the high-flying lecturer speaks:

Reaching for the book he planned to quote from, he may assay a little quip, confiding that he hopes he brought the right one. I believe that once the show has seriously begun, these efforts to frankly project oneself exclusively in one’s capacity as an animator are not likely to come off—at least not as frequently as speakers believe. Nonetheless the liberty is often taken. (pp. 185–186)

In the fifth section, he attempts to “put the pieces together.” Just as a lecture cannot be reduced to a text that can be read at home, neither can it be reduced to listening to a recording. There are two reasons for this, linked to the very

fact of attending an event. Goffman speaks of access and celebration. Direct visual and aural access to a speaker whom the audience may already know from his or her publications or from the news leads to the formation of a “one-sided social relationship with him or her.” What’s more, “in thus gaining access to an authority, the audience also gains ritual access to the subject matter over which the speaker has command.” But Goffman qualifies this, adding in parentheses: “Substantive access is quite another matter” (p. 187).

Celebration is the set of markers that will give the impression that a lecture has been produced exclusively for a particular occasion and audience: He mentions little local phrases, a feeling of freshness in the reading thanks to a “hyper smooth” effect as on the radio. But watch out for the mess if the speaker gets lost in a sentence and has to read it all over again. Illusion and vulnerability go hand in hand: Goffman always comes back to this issue, which runs through all his work, from the “safe supplies” (refuge activities) described in his doctoral dissertation to the “tripping over the carpet” (p. 183) of the lecture podium.

Finally, in the sixth section, Goffman once again takes up the question: What does the speaker bring along to the podium? The answer is twofold. As in any interaction, he brings with him the “wider world of structures and positions” (p. 193). Here we find both the Goffman of the “fuzzy coupling” between micro and macro, and the Bourdieu who wrote in 1972 that “the truth of interaction never resides entirely in interaction” (1972, p. 184). But Goffman goes further: What the speaker finally brings with him to the podium is confirmation that there is “structure in the world [and] that this structure can be perceived and reported.” A contract is thus established between the lecturer and the audience:

The lecturer and the audience join in affirming a single proposition. They join in affirming that organized talking can reflect, express, delineate, portray—if not come to grips with—the real world, and that, finally, there is a real, structured, somewhat unitary world out there to comprehend. (1981, p. 194)

Far from being a public entertainer, the lecturer is a “functionary of the cognitive establishment”:

Whatever his substantive domain, whatever his school of thought, and whatever his inclination to piety or impiety, he signs the same agreement and he serves the same cause: to protect us from the wind, to stand up and seriously project the assumption that through lecturing, a meaningful picture of some part of the

world can be conveyed, and that the talker can have access to a picture worth conveying. (pp. 194–195)

Goffman thus ends his lecture in a very emphatic manner, but this final solemnity is undoubtedly not reducible to a display of rhetorical pomp. It seems clear that the reason he gave so many lectures in his career was not to supplement his income. Rather, it was because he believed in this ministry of cognitive power. For him, the lecture was clearly more than just a friendly chat, as evidenced by the repeated expulsion of photographers. He gave it his all, feeling, as already discussed, vested with a mission. This mission was not one of popularization—while not outright obscure, his lectures made few concessions to ease—but of introduction to an understanding of the world.

From Performed Work to Performative Work

We have now heard Goffman talk about his conception of the lecture—and he saw it as noble, unquestionably. This mission is perfectly illustrated by his lectures on the ritualization of femininity, which he apparently agreed to give free of charge on numerous occasions for feminist groups.² In revealing the relations of domination underlying advertising photographs, Goffman is very much in the position of the functionary of cognitive power who shares a “meaningful picture of some part of the world” (1981, pp. 194–195).

This vision did not exclude others, which Goffman did not mention explicitly, but which can be inferred from the information we have gleaned on his journey through the United States and Europe. To begin with the least noble: money. It is true that Goffman always asked for fees, and high ones at that. But it should be remembered that US academics are always paid for their lectures, and that they are part of a competitive arena among speakers from a wide variety of backgrounds, including the arts, politics, and sports. By charging the equivalent of \$10,000 per lecture at SUNY Buffalo in today’s dollar, Goffman was consolidating his authority vis-à-vis academic and non-academic competitors—even if, for some of them, he was only a low stakes player.

More noble is the function of symbolic banker, as mentioned above. On a number of occasions, Goffman agreed to support a young colleague, or to visit a lesser-known university with completely unknown colleagues. His role as lecturer-banker can be linked to other operations of symbolic transfer.

² Information provided by Gillian Sankoff in a conversation on April 1, 1986.

For example, certain highly capitalized academics agree to serve on thesis committees to reinforce the stature of their graduate students. Generally speaking—unlike Bourdieu, for example, he played this role sparingly. He directed or co-directed a few theses, but always sought to limit their number. We know of no prefaces or afterwords authored by him, perhaps because he realized before his colleagues that this all-too-frequently-used practice yields very little in exchange for the time required.

A classic function of academic lectures is to prow for an article or book in the process of being written. One might assume that Goffman made great use of the lecture's ability to pull rabbits out of a hat, considering the number of talks he gave on the ritualization of femininity or frame analysis, for example. But it is important to remember that Goffman read very few written texts. So he did not put himself in the position of partially improvising to "elaborate upon" an idea in gestation. Insofar as the texts of his lectures are not available, with the exception of "The Lecture," it is difficult to measure the gaps between his presentations and his publications. He did not read chapters from his books in public, yet he was careful to deliver dense, totally mastered lectures, often without the slightest flourish. It is possible to venture the hypothesis that, alongside Goffman's written work, which is well-known and available today, there is an oral body of work, one which is still poorly known and almost totally unavailable. The contrast with the fate reserved for Bourdieu's or Foucault's lectures at the Collège de France is striking: Thick volumes of transcriptions of the two scholars' lectures, supplemented by copious notes and commentaries, regularly appear in bookshops. These posthumous works very rarely deliver new elements, but they complement, reinforce, and refine the written work, sometimes in spectacular fashion (for example, Bourdieu's *Manet*, published in 2013). In Goffman's case, we can imagine a similar corpus, given the number of lectures he prepared, but there is very little chance that we will ever uncover it. So we must turn our attention elsewhere. No matter how impossible it is to locate the printed versions of Goffman's lectures (if any such versions exist), it is worth exploring his oral work, since that was not only performed work but performative work.

Although Goffman probably did not use his lectures to test out works in progress on different audiences, we cannot rule out the idea that his lectures were like so many micro-terrains for observation or experimentation. The *breaching experiments* of Garfinkel and Milgram are well known. They were based on the principle of deviating from or breaking an implicit "rule" of

behavior. In this respect, Goffman's moves against photographers, repeated on numerous occasions, have all the air of destabilization experiments. The same applies to his (strange) requests for constant contact with the New York Stock Exchange. Or his late arrival in Brussels for the podium. However, these are only suppositions, or rather attributions of intent. It may simply be that Goffman could not bear the intrusion of photographers just as he was beginning to concentrate on the text of his lecture. It may be that he needed to be in regular contact with his broker. It may be that he needed to go to the bathroom before starting his speech. But this possibility, if not plausibility, of putting his sociology into practice in his lectures opens the way to an interpretation in terms of a performed work. Without seeking to systematically correlate his work with his lectures—there are books for which no antecedent public lecture can be found, such as *Stigma*—it is possible to see his presentations as performative formulations of his writings. Not illustrations, and not didactic aids, like the slides in his lectures on the ritualization of femininity, but low-key notional performances, only grasped by a few in the audience. It was only with "The Lecture" that this turning of the work on itself can be understood explicitly. Yet we can go one step further and consider Goffman's lectures as contributions to his intellectual maturation. We can then consider his lectures as his performative work.

How to do things with words: Austin's formula about performative verbs, which produce what they enunciate, such as "I baptize you," has undoubtedly been abused. No need to detail the twists and turns of the debates on "performativity" that run from Derrida to Butler to Searle. It will suffice to quote Aaron Cicourel in an interview he gave me on April 18, 1985. After describing Goffman's investment in the preparation of his lectures,³ he added a somewhat cryptic comment:

He could talk to people who weren't in academia—or even academics who weren't too intellectual. He used a lot of American slang. He was very good at that [pause]. There's a huge academic audience that's not very intellectually active. That includes students as well as teachers. I don't know if he addressed non-academic audiences. But within the academic world . . . if you want to win a prize, you have to popularize. Otherwise, it's very difficult, very difficult. Garfinkel would have liked to go there, but he didn't know how.

Goffman knew how: difference and repetition. He produced powerful lectures, both in content and vocabulary, with their mix of seriousness and

³ See p. 20–21 in this book.

deadpan humor, and he performed on stage very often—but only within the academic world, be it universities, colloquia, or conferences. His performances performed him, in the sense that they gradually led him to become Goffman, with all his aura, all his mystery, all his power, right up to the presidency of the American Sociological Association. Of course, this final step in his career was the result of intense lobbying by a small group of unconditional admirers. But their work could not have succeeded had it not been based on the enormous reserve of capital Goffman had accumulated over the years.

This is where we must be wary of retrospective interpretations. Goffman's career should not be reduced to that of a sociologist who realized at a very young age that, to make a name for himself in the academic world, it was advisable to make frequent public appearances, parallel to numerous publications. The process of symbolic accumulation that produced Goffman was first and foremost the result of a vision of the sociologist's craft that he himself enunciated, based on the ministry of cognitive power: sharing with audiences a sensible image of a certain part of the world. But in doing so, a performative dynamic was set in motion over the years, leading Erving to become Goffman.

Goffman Between Cage and Duyckaerts

It would be tempting to slip Goffman into the world of performance art, in particular the lecture-performance as it developed a few years ago in the field of contemporary art.⁴ If Goffman were still alive, he would undoubtedly be in great demand in art schools, playing the role of awakener-performer in the manner of Bruno Latour.

We can note here that Goffman was familiar with the work of John Cage, whom he mentioned in his third lecture in Buffalo in 1970. (He refers to "Imaginary Landscape No. 4" from 1951, which features twelve "musicians" turning the knobs of radio sets.) Goffman spoke of it seemingly ironically: "People sat and laughed softly, but they took it well," according to the quote from a journalist who attended the lecture (Anonymous, 1970).⁵ Years later, he would joke again about Cage in "The Lecture," speaking of "the John Cage school of performance rip-offs," a humorous touch to warm up his audience at the start of the lecture (Goffman, 1981, p. 162). There is no reason

⁴ In this section, I draw on a number of works, without claiming to be either exhaustive or representative: Roselee Goldberg (2001), Josette Féra (2012), Aurore Després (2016), Vangelis Athanassopoulos (2018), and Laurence Corbel and Christophe Viart (2021).

⁵ Cf. Anonymous (1970, p. 24).

to think that he took Cage's work seriously, but he was clearly familiar with it. Moreover, he and Cage shared the same theoretical underpinnings: All public behavior is a performance; all you have to do to perform is to be on stage without saying anything (allusion to Cage's silent piece, *4'33"*, 1952).

It doesn't matter whether they knew each other personally or intellectually. The important part is that Goffman's work can be compared with the work of various contemporary artists who have been part of the performance movement in visual art and in dance. "Hotel Palenque," the lecture given by Robert Smithson at the University of Utah on January 24, 1972 (now in the collections of the Guggenheim in New York), can be compared with Goffman's slide lectures. Smithson is the great figure of American land art, known for works inscribed in the landscape, which slowly unravel over the years. His lecture is a stroll through a dilapidated Mexican hotel, left to the passage of time. Common to both Goffman and Smithson was the use of a slide projector, which became an integral part of their lectures:

The slide-illustrated lecture calls for a device that involves several elements. Unlike cinema, the projector occupies the same space as the spectators. It is thus affirmed as the agent who presides over the exhibition of photography. . . . By placing the experience of images in a semi-darkened space, projection assigns a place to the photograph, the speaker, and the audience. To these elements is added a sound material in its own right: the dry noise of the camera marking each slide change is combined with the hum of the projector's blower and the fluctuations of the commentator's voice. (Boulouch & Corbel, 2021, p. 39–40)

It may well be that neither Smithson nor Goffman intentionally played with all the performative registers of the slide apparatus, that they just used it because it was the apparatus available at the time. But the fact is that they both set up this simple yet cumbersome device, that they literally staged it, plunging the audience into darkness and making their voices emerge from the gloom, mingled with the noise of the fan and the dust particles dancing in the light of the projector. The difference between Smithson and Goffman is that the latter used this device on many, many occasions, whereas only a few of Smithson's lectures are known. This brings Goffman even closer to the contemporary art world, where one of the strongest approaches is that of the three R's: Reconstruction, Replication, and Re-enactment.⁶

⁶ Two books have recently identified this movement in various fields: Sven Dupré et al. (2020) and Marion Colas-Blaise and Gian Maria Tore (2021).

Re-enacting a performance, reassembling an exhibition, restoring behavior,⁷ are all gestures that run through the history of contemporary art. For example, Goffman's series of lectures on the ritualization of femininity, using the same set of slides, could be seen as the "re-enactment" of an initial performance. Dare we go so far as to compare him to Robert Cantarella, whose lecture-performance *Faire le Gilles* consisted in repeating word for word Gilles Deleuze's lectures at Vincennes and Paris-8, with the same intonations, hesitations, and coughing fits (Cantarella, 2021)? It would be Goffman performing Goffman, which may be a bit far-fetched. And then there is Eric Duyckaerts, who also demanded that his lectures—performances—be neither filmed nor recorded, another point of similarity with Goffman.

Duyckaerts gave an impression of unfailing scientific seriousness: a sober suit, a stern countenance, constantly inscribing learned names and words on large sheets of flipchart paper with a black felt-tip pen; the Belgian performer was constantly oscillating between posture and imposture, as he liked to say (Corbel, 2021). Goffman, on the other hand, was neither posture nor imposture. He was legitimately in earnest, offering genuine scholarly lectures. But when he interrupted himself to chase away a photographer, did he not produce a rupture in the frame much as an artist seeking to break the code with an unexpected gesture?⁸ A bit like Duyckaerts, who could start talking faster and faster, or producing a face increasingly ravaged by tics?

Conversely, when Goffman read his text with little expression, without raising his head too much, was he perhaps being Guillaume Désanges *avant la lettre*? Désanges, now head of the Palais de Tokyo, who gave a lecture entitled *Signs and Wonders* in the 2010s without making a gesture, without raising his voice, in the half-light of a shadow theater. When Éric Valette says that "where scientific communication implies a clear and univocal apprehension of discourse, performance, like any artistic form, is marked by a

⁷ The allusion here is to a famous article by anthropologist and theater specialist Richard Schechner, "The Restoration of Behavior" (1985).

⁸ In April 1975, Goffman participated in the Amsterdam Festival of Social Sciences, organized by his friend Alvin Gouldner. He showed his four hundred slides about gender advertisements. There were more than one thousand people in attendance. Among them was Amsterdam-based sociologist Paul Brennan, who had brought along a tape recorder. In a write-up of the event, Brennan documents yet another outburst from Goffman: "During his performance, a photographer moved to center stage and snapped Goffman's picture. He stopped the show. 'I'm here speaking to this audience. I'm not speaking to the press of any kind and I prefer that there be no taping or photographing or anything of that kind. All these things detract from such little that can go on between myself and yourselves. I'm offended by being photographed. I'm conducting a campaign against the press. The stage is dirty enough as it is without further contamination.' Less than a minute later a member of the festival committee came and switched off my tape recorder" (1975, p. 55).

certain complexity, opacity and polysemy” (2018, p. 163), we might wonder whether Goffman’s lectures don’t better meet the criteria of artistic performance, and Désanges’s the codes of scientific communication.

Let me stop here. The answer I want to give to my initial question is finally taking shape. When I began this work, I wondered how and why Goffman’s work never ages. At least part of the answer is that few sociologists born in 1922 could be invited to maintain a dialogue with the management of the Palais de Tokyo in 2022. Goffman’s contemporaneity lies in the fact that, yesterday, he had already found ways of asking today’s questions.